Emma

A simplified retelling

Original story by Jane Austen

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. A quiet house

Emma Woodhouse lived with her father at Hartfield, near the village of Highbury. She was clever, comfortable and used to having her own way. She loved her father, who worried about changes, visitors' health and almost everything connected with food.

For many years, Miss Taylor had lived with them as Emma's teacher and companion. Now Miss Taylor had married Mr Weston and moved to Randalls. Emma was happy for her, but the house felt much quieter.

Emma believed she had helped arrange the marriage. Her neighbour, Mr Knightley, was less convinced. He thought the couple had fallen in love quite naturally.

"You were fortunate in your guess," he suggested.

Emma preferred to think she had a special talent for understanding other people's hearts. She did not want to marry herself. With a home, money and a father who needed her, she saw little reason to change her life.

But arranging happiness for someone else sounded like an excellent occupation.

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2. A new friend

Emma became friendly with Harriet Smith, a young woman who had been educated at a local school. Harriet did not know much about her parents. She was affectionate and easily impressed by Emma’s confidence.

Harriet had stayed with the Martin family at their farm. She spoke warmly about them, especially Robert Martin. He was a sensible, hardworking young man who liked her very much.

Emma decided that Harriet should aim for a more important marriage. She imagined that Harriet might have a wealthy or distinguished family. There was little evidence for this, but Emma enjoyed the possibility.

When Robert Martin proposed, Harriet asked Emma what she should do. Emma said that the decision must be Harriet’s. Yet her questions and comments made her own opinion perfectly clear.

Harriet refused him.

Mr Knightley was angry when he learned what had

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happened. He knew and respected Robert Martin. He believed that Harriet had rejected an excellent man because Emma had encouraged her to think too highly of her position.

Emma disagreed. She already had another husband in mind for her friend.

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3. Mr Elton’s attentions

Mr Elton was the local clergyman. He was polite and often visited Hartfield. Emma thought his interest in their household meant that he admired Harriet.

When Emma drew Harriet’s portrait, Elton praised it enthusiastically and offered to have it framed. Emma considered this convincing evidence of his feelings.

She collected other small signs. A kind word, a visit or a compliment could become part of the story she was creating. Harriet began to believe it too.

Mr Knightley saw things differently. He thought Elton cared about money and status and would choose a wife accordingly. Emma believed he was being unfair.

At a Christmas gathering, Harriet was absent because she was ill. Emma expected Elton to be disappointed. Instead, his attention remained fixed on Emma herself.

On the journey home, they found themselves alone in a carriage. Elton suddenly declared his love and proposed to Emma.

She was astonished. She explained that she had thought

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he cared for Harriet. He was astonished in return. He had never intended to marry Harriet at all.

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4. A painful mistake

Emma refused Elton. For the first time, she had to face a serious failure in her matchmaking. His praise of the portrait had been praise directed towards the artist, not the young woman in the picture.

Telling Harriet was difficult. Harriet was deeply hurt, while Emma felt responsible for creating expectations that had no real foundation.

Elton soon left Highbury. Later, the news arrived that he was engaged to a wealthy young woman named Augusta Hawkins.

Emma began to recognise that she could be mistaken about people. But recognising one mistake did not immediately remove her confidence in all her other opinions.

Meanwhile, another visitor was expected. Mr Weston’s son, Frank Churchill, had been raised by wealthy relatives. His father wanted him to visit, and Mrs Weston hoped that he and Emma would like one another.

Emma had never met Frank, but she was already curious

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about him. An unfamiliar person offered plenty of room for imagination.

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5. Jane Fairfax returns

Jane Fairfax came to stay with her aunt, Miss Bates, and her grandmother. Jane had lost her parents as a child and had grown up with the kindly Campbell family.

She was accomplished, especially at music. Without money of her own, however, she expected to become a governess. This meant leaving people she loved and earning her living in another family’s home.

Emma did not find it easy to like Jane. Jane was reserved, and Emma sometimes felt uncomfortable beside someone whose musical skill was so much greater than her own.

Miss Bates spoke about Jane with great affection. She also spoke about many other things, often at considerable length. Emma sometimes grew impatient with her.

A fine piano unexpectedly arrived for Jane. Nobody knew who had sent it. Emma began to imagine a secret connection between Jane and Mr Dixon, the husband of her friend from the Campbell household.

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Once again, a small mystery became an invitation to invent a much larger story.

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6. Frank Churchill

Frank Churchill finally arrived in Highbury. He was charming, lively and attentive to Emma. She enjoyed his company and thought that their friendship might become a romance.

Frank joined her in joking and guessing about Jane’s piano. Emma did not understand how much he already knew about Jane.

Jane and Frank had met before coming to Highbury. They were secretly engaged. Frank feared that the aunt who had raised him would oppose the marriage and damage his future prospects.

Emma knew none of this. To her, Frank seemed like an agreeable young man who understood her humour.

Mr Knightley was less pleased with him. He disliked Frank’s long delay in visiting his father and questioned some of his behaviour. Emma thought he was judging Frank too severely.

As Frank’s visit continued, Emma began to notice that she was not as deeply attached to him as she had

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expected. She could enjoy his attention without constantly thinking about him when he was away.

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7. Mrs Elton enters Highbury

After their marriage, Mr and Mrs Elton returned to Highbury. Mrs Elton was confident, wealthy and eager to demonstrate her importance.

She spoke freely about her connections and offered advice that people had not requested. Emma found her manners irritating.

Mrs Elton took a particular interest in Jane Fairfax. She insisted that she could help Jane find a position as a governess. Jane did not welcome the pressure, though she tried to remain polite.

The Eltons also treated Harriet unkindly. Harriet had done nothing to deserve it, and Emma could see how painful their behaviour was for her friend.

Yet Emma’s dislike of Mrs Elton did not mean that Emma always understood her own faults. She could recognise another person’s snobbery much more quickly than she could recognise the influence of social rank on her own decisions.

Highbury’s social gatherings continued, bringing the

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same neighbours together and giving everyone further opportunities to misunderstand one another.

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8. The dance

At a dance, Harriet was left without a partner. Mr Elton made it clear that he would not dance with her. The refusal was intended to hurt.

Mr Knightley stepped forward and asked Harriet to dance. His kindness saved her from an embarrassing situation.

Emma was grateful. Watching him, she saw how different his considerate behaviour was from Elton’s coldness. Later, she and Knightley spoke more warmly to each other.

For Harriet, the dance was even more important than Emma realised. Knightley’s attention stayed in her thoughts.

Not long afterwards, Harriet was frightened during an encounter with a group of strangers. Frank helped her and brought her safely to Hartfield.

When Harriet later hinted that she admired someone above her own social position, Emma assumed she meant Frank. She encouraged Harriet to hope, while

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promising herself that she would not arrange another marriage.

Unfortunately, she had not checked whether she understood whom Harriet was talking about.

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9. A day at Box Hill

A group of friends went to Box Hill for an outing. The place was beautiful, but the conversation became uncomfortable.

Frank was restless and encouraged a game in which the guests were asked to say something clever or amusing. Miss Bates joked about her own habit of talking too much.

Emma replied with a sharp comment that made fun of her. It was a clever remark, but it was also cruel. Miss Bates understood that she had been laughed at and tried to hide how much it hurt.

Later, Mr Knightley spoke to Emma privately. He told her that her behaviour had been wrong. Miss Bates had little money and depended on the kindness of neighbours. Emma’s position gave her words particular power.

Emma was ashamed. This time, she did not find an easy excuse for herself. She had used her confidence to wound someone who had always treated her with affection.

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The next morning, she visited Miss Bates. She wanted her concern to be shown through attention and action, rather than through a clever explanation of why she had not meant any harm.

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10. Jane’s distress

Jane seemed increasingly unhappy. She avoided some invitations and appeared anxious about the future. Emma tried to be kinder, but she still understood very little of what was troubling her.

Jane’s secret engagement had become painful. Frank’s public attentions to Emma hurt her, and hiding their relationship made an already uncertain position more difficult.

At last, Jane accepted a position as a governess. She was preparing to leave Highbury and had reached a breaking point in her relationship with Frank.

Then Frank’s aunt died. The circumstances that had kept the engagement secret changed, and the truth could finally be told.

When Emma learned that Frank and Jane were engaged, many small events suddenly looked different. The piano had been Frank’s gift. His behaviour towards Jane had hidden a relationship, not a dislike.

Emma was relieved that she had never truly loved him.

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But she also had to recognise that his conduct had been unfair to Jane, and that her own amusing guesses about Jane had been unkind and mistaken.

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11. Harriet’s surprise

Emma worried that Harriet would be heartbroken by the news about Frank. She prepared to comfort her gently.

But Harriet was not in love with Frank.

The man she admired was Mr Knightley.

Emma listened in shock as Harriet explained how much his kindness at the dance had meant to her. Harriet believed there were other signs that he might return her feelings.

In that moment, Emma understood something about herself that she had never properly considered. She loved Knightley. The thought of him marrying Harriet was deeply painful.

She was ashamed of her reaction. Harriet had followed the hope that Emma herself had encouraged. Emma could hardly blame her for being honest about it.

She also began to see how much her own happiness had depended on Knightley’s presence. His visits, his judgement and even their disagreements had become part of the life she valued most.

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She had spent so much time imagining other people’s feelings that she had failed to understand her own.

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12. An honest conversation

Mr Knightley returned after a visit to London. He had heard about Frank and Jane and worried that Emma might be upset.

When they spoke, Emma explained that Frank had not broken her heart. She had never been as attached to him as people might have believed.

Knightley was relieved. Then he began to explain his own feelings.

Emma was frightened for a moment. She thought he might be about to tell her that he loved Harriet. Nevertheless, she tried to listen generously.

Instead, he told Emma that he loved her.

Their conversation brought relief, surprise and happiness. They knew each other’s faults, and neither needed to pretend to be an ideal person. Their affection had grown through years of friendship and honest disagreement.

Emma now had two difficult matters to consider. She must think about Harriet’s disappointment. She must

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also think about her father, who would be distressed by any plan that seemed likely to take his daughter away from Hartfield.

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13. Harriet chooses again

Harriet went to stay with Emma’s sister, Isabella, and her family in London. During the visit, she met Robert Martin again.

His feelings for her had not disappeared. He proposed a second time, and Harriet accepted.

When Emma learned the news, she was sincerely pleased. She could now recognise what she had refused to see before: Harriet and Robert Martin suited one another. He was a good man, and Harriet’s happiness did not depend on Emma choosing a more impressive husband for her.

Harriet also discovered that her father was a tradesman. The grand family history Emma had imagined had been a fantasy.

This did not make Harriet’s affection or happiness less valuable. It showed how little Emma’s confident guesses had rested on actual knowledge.

Their friendship would change as their lives changed, but Emma could be grateful that Harriet had found a future

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based on her own real feelings.

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14. A home for the future

Emma and Knightley discussed how to marry without making Mr Woodhouse miserable. Knightley offered to live at Hartfield, allowing Emma to remain with her father.

Mr Woodhouse still worried. Change was difficult for him, even when the people around him were happy. Eventually, the idea of Knightley living in the house began to seem reassuring, especially after reports of thefts from nearby poultry houses.

Other marriages also brought the story towards its close. Harriet married Robert Martin. Frank and Jane could look forward to a life in which their affection no longer had to be hidden.

Emma married Knightley with a much clearer understanding of herself than she had possessed at the beginning.

She was still lively, intelligent and capable of making mistakes. Her growth did not require her to become a completely different person. It required her to question the certainty with which she had judged other people.

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She had learned that caring about a friend was different from directing the friend’s life. A pleasing story was different from a well-supported conclusion. And being clever offered little protection against being wrong.

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Words to keep

companion — someone who spends time with another person. Miss Taylor had been Emma’s teacher and companion.

matchmaking — trying to arrange romantic relationships between other people. Emma’s matchmaking caused several misunderstandings.

accomplished — very skilled at something. Jane was an accomplished musician.

governess — a woman employed to teach children in a private home. Jane expected to earn her living as a governess.

reserved — quiet about your thoughts and feelings. Emma found Jane’s reserved manner difficult to understand.

snobbery — treating people as less important because of their social position. Emma found it easier to notice Mrs Elton’s snobbery than her own.

considerate — careful about other people’s feelings and needs. Knightley’s invitation to dance was considerate.

certainty — the feeling that something is definitely true.

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Emma’s certainty often grew faster than her knowledge.

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After reading

Why does Emma misunderstand Mr Elton’s interest? Which pieces of evidence does she interpret incorrectly?

Compare Emma’s advice to Harriet at the beginning with her response to Harriet’s final engagement. What has changed?

Why does Knightley’s criticism after Box Hill affect Emma so strongly? Consider Miss Bates’s position in their community.

Choose one example of a character changing their mind after learning something new. What does the change reveal about them?

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